

Chapter 77-4

Xu Qingzhu clearly sensed the movement beside her. When Sheng Linlang got up to leave, she finally struggled to open her eyes and called out in a hoarse voice: "Mom."

"Mm." Sheng Linlang said: "It's still early. You two chat for a bit before going back to sleep."

"Where are you going?" The moment Xu Qingzhu spoke, she felt like her throat had been ground by sand—hoarse.

Sheng Linlang chuckled softly, "You're chatting and acting spoiled with your wife. Am I supposed to stay here and be a third wheel?"¹

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I'm going back to find your dad." Sheng Linlang said: "After sharing a bed for so many years, I'm not used to having someone else beside me."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She laughed lazily, "Then go ahead."

After Sheng Linlang left the room, Xu Qingzhu picked up the water cup by the bed and took a sip. After drinking, she frowned, and Liang Shi understood: "Is it cold water?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Too cold."

"What nightmare did you have?" Liang Shi asked gently: "Why were you crying so much?"

Xu Qingzhu realized belatedly, "I was crying?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Touch your nose. It's still wet."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the headboard, tilted her head back, and closed her eyes again. "It was a very sad dream."

"Sorry." Liang Shi said: "I disturbed your sleep."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu sighed softly, even her voice carrying lingering sadness. "I went to bed early tonight."

Even through the screen, Liang Shi could feel her helplessness and couldn't help but ask: "Is it about your mom and dad?"

When this form of address came from Liang Shi's mouth, Xu Qingzhu immediately knew who she was referring to.

Not the Xu family parents, but her biological parents.

She tilted her head slightly, her eyelashes casting heavy shadows on her lower eyelids, her lashes trembling faintly. With her eyes half-closed, she said softly: "Yes."

Two light words, yet they carried all her emotions—too complex to put into words.

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi looked at her through the screen and suddenly said gently: "Let me come to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"It's too late." Xu Qingzhu said: "It takes half an hour to drive."

"There's no traffic now." Liang Shi said: "It's still early. I can be there in twenty minutes."

Xu Qingzhu was speechless.

Liang Shi added: "I have something I need to discuss with you."

It wasn't until after hanging up the video call that Xu Qingzhu saw the messages Liang Shi had sent her.

[Is it okay to move this Saturday?]

[Although you don't like me asking about everything, I still feel this is something for two people to decide, so I want to discuss it with you.]

[Teacher Xu, what are you doing?]

[Are you asleep?]

[It's not your bedtime yet.]

[We'll move to Zhao Xuning's place. It's a bit small, but I'll give you the master bedroom. It has a bay window.]

[When I have money later, I'll buy a really big one in that complex.]

[I'll have money soon.]

[.....]

Liang Shi, who usually didn't talk much, had an unusually large number of messages today. She had probably sensed that something was off with her emotions, so she kept sending messages.

One every few minutes, but at that time Xu Qingzhu had been chatting with Sheng Linlang and went to sleep after their talk, so she hadn't noticed at all.

Looking at them now, Liang Shi's messages had filled the screen.

It gave her an indescribable sense of security.

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When Liang Shi drove to the Xu family's front gate, she suddenly realized... she had been impulsive.

What she actually needed to say was just about moving on Saturday, and that was merely a clumsy excuse.

The real reason was that seeing the sadness Xu Qingzhu conveyed through the screen, and the fragility beneath her sorrowful expression, she really wanted to be there with her.

Spending the night with unsettling bad emotions would make a person feel miserable.

She had experienced it firsthand, so she wanted to accompany Xu Qingzhu through this sad and difficult night.

In a moment of impulse, she had come up with a clumsy excuse and came over.

But when the car stopped, she let out a light breath.

In what capacity had she come?

In what position had she come?

And where would she stay after arriving?

Liang Shi gently closed her eyes, thought for a moment, and then got out of the car anyway.

She thought to herself: I'll go take a look first. If it doesn't work out, I'll just drive back.

As soon as Liang Shi got out of the car, she saw the person standing at the front gate.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a light-colored cardigan, with a pure white cotton T-shirt underneath and a pair of loose gray pants. She had cotton slippers on her feet, her hair dancing in the wind. That palm-sized little face looked bright and pure under the faint light.

She stood at the entrance with her arms crossed, looking around, and soon spotted Liang Shi. She smiled at her and gave a light wave.

Liang Shi stood there, and suddenly felt at ease.

She walked over and asked in a low voice: "Why did you come out to wait?"

Xu Qingzhu had been standing outside for a while, and her nose was frozen red. Her voice had also been frozen soft, that cool, clear tone nearly blown away by the wind, leaving only softness. Yet she opened her arms toward her: "Teacher Liang, let's have a hug."

Liang Shi was stunned. Xu Qingzhu had already stepped forward, burying her head in the crook of her neck, her breath falling on her neck and the tips of her hair, her arms tightening around her waist.

Their bodies pressed close without warning. Liang Shi stood dazed for a moment before reaching out to gently pat her back, coaxing her softly: "I'm here."

¹ "Third wheel" (電燈泡, diàn dēng pào) - Literally translates to "light bulb." This is Chinese slang for someone who is an unwanted presence when two people want to be alone together, similar to the English expression "third wheel." The imagery suggests that the extra person is like a bright light bulb, illuminating a situation that the couple would prefer to keep private or intimate.